

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Software Quality Assurance and Testing English



Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Software quality assurance analysts, manual testers, test engineers, automation engineers, and test leads.

All products, builds, test data, results, and incidents are fictional English-language practice, not a testing certification course, security assessment, implementation manual, or release authorization. Quality assurance includes broader quality practices; these lessons focus on testing communication within those roles. Use the actual product contract, tools, evidence, qualified reviewers, and local decision responsibilities in real work. No specific platform behavior or universal defect-rating scheme is implied.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

acceptance criterion

A specific condition that a feature or change must satisfy to be accepted by the relevant stakeholders.

actual result

The behavior or output observed during a particular test execution.

ambiguity

Wording or evidence that permits more than one plausible interpretation of intended behavior.

blocked test

A test that cannot be completed as intended because a required condition, resource, or dependency is unavailable.

boundary value

An input at or near a limit where specified behavior may change.

decision table

A structured representation connecting combinations of conditions with their expected actions or outcomes.

defect triage

A review that clarifies reported problems and determines their handling, ownership, and attention order.

duplicate report

A report established to describe an already-recorded defect rather than a distinct issue.

equivalence partition

A group of inputs or states expected to receive similar treatment for the rule being tested.

exit criterion

An agreed condition used to determine whether a testing activity can be considered complete.

expected result

The outcome a test is meant to check against a stated requirement or other justified basis.

exploratory testing

Testing in which learning about the software informs the design and execution of further checks during the activity.

false positive

A test result that incorrectly signals a product problem when the claimed problem is not present.

flaky test

A test producing inconsistent outcomes across repeated runs without an intended relevant change to the tested software.

heuristic

A practical thinking aid for choosing investigations, useful but not a guaranteed rule for correctness.

negative test

A test examining behavior under invalid inputs, disallowed actions, or other specified exceptional conditions.

precondition

A required state or condition that must hold before a test's actions begin.

priority

The relative urgency or order assigned to investigating or resolving an issue.

regression testing

Testing for unintended effects of changes on existing behavior, including behavior outside the changed area.

reproduction steps

An ordered description of actions used to make an observed behavior occur again.

residual risk

The possibility of adverse outcomes that remains after the checks and other measures already taken.

severity

The degree of impact of a defect, assessed using the team's stated context and rating scheme.

smoke test

A limited initial check of important basic functions used to assess whether further testing is practical.

test charter

A focused statement of what an exploratory session will investigate and why.

test coverage

The extent to which tests address a stated set of requirements, code structures, risks, or other defined items.

test environment

The software, configuration, data, and other conditions in which testing is performed.

test fixture

The data and setup needed to give a test its intended starting conditions.

test isolation

Keeping a test's relevant state and outcome independent of unintended effects from other tests.

test oracle

A source or method used to determine whether an observed software result is acceptable or correct.

test summary

A report of testing scope, execution results, limitations, and relevant remaining concerns.

timebox

A fixed period allocated to an activity, limiting effort without guaranteeing complete coverage.

traceability

Explicit links connecting requirements, tests, results, and related defects or other supporting records.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask what makes the result correct

For input ___, source A expects ___ while source B expects ___.

Which source should govern the equality case?

The observed result is ___; the expected result is still ___.

A test oracle is the basis for judging the result, not necessarily another program. When wording and examples conflict, state the precise input whose outcome is uncertain and ask the responsible person to settle it.

Word combinations in this lesson

establish the test oracle: identify a credible basis for judging an outcome

clarify a boundary rule: settle what happens at a stated limit

compare expected and actual results: distinguish the specified outcome from the observation

resolve conflicting examples: determine which source expresses the intended behavior

Request a comparable reproduction

Start with ___ on build ___.

After ___, I observed ___ in ___ attempts.

Your attempt differs in ___; could we align that condition?

A clear report distinguishes preconditions from steps and actual behavior from expected behavior. Two failures in two attempts are a bounded observation, not a claim that every user always fails.

Word combinations in this lesson

state the starting state: describe conditions that must hold before the actions

identify the tested build: specify the version that produced the observation

preserve the failing sequence: retain the order of actions that led to the failure

report reproduction frequency: state how often the behavior occurred in recorded attempts

Explain why another middle value adds little

These values all represent ___, while ___ is missing.

At ___ the expected result changes from ___ to ___.

The requirement covers ___ but does not specify ___.

Partitioning groups inputs expected to receive similar treatment. Boundary cases probe transitions between groups. Neither approach means one successful sample proves every value behaves correctly; explain the selection and its limits.

Word combinations in this lesson

cover both sides of a boundary: examine values immediately inside and outside a limit

choose a representative input: select a value from a justified behavior group

exercise a rule combination: check a specified combination of conditions

check rejection behavior: observe how the system handles disallowed input

Compare checks by the risk they address

This check covers ___, whereas the change affects ___.

Because ___ is shared, ___ is a relevant regression concern.

Within the available time, I propose ___; ___ would remain untested.

Coverage needs a named basis, such as requirements, paths, or configurations. A large test count does not establish that the changed behavior was checked. Describe the selection's rationale and the work left outside it.

Word combinations in this lesson

map a check to a requirement: show which stated behavior a test examines

identify an untested path: name a workflow not exercised by the evidence

prioritize by change risk: focus limited checking on plausible consequences of a change

distinguish breadth from depth: separate many touched areas from thorough examination of each

Explain an unstable result without dismissing it

The same build passes when __ but fails when __.

The fixture difference is __, which supports __.

That explains this result pattern, not every possible __.

An inconsistent test result still deserves investigation. Passing on rerun doesn't erase the earlier evidence. Once a fixture interaction is identified, limit the conclusion to that interaction rather than treating all failures as noise.

Word combinations in this lesson

retain the first failure: preserve evidence even when a rerun passes

reset the starting data: restore the stated fixture before an independent attempt

separate product and test causes: distinguish a software defect from a check's own problem

compare isolated and grouped runs: examine whether neighboring tests affect the result

Keep severity and priority distinct

The impact is __; the scheduling reason is __.

Can we agree the affected workflow before assigning __?

These reports share __, but we have not established __.

Severity describes impact; priority concerns the order or urgency of attention. A visible issue can be urgent without becoming more functionally damaging. Use the team's stated rating scheme rather than inventing universal labels.

Word combinations in this lesson

describe the user impact: state what a person cannot do or receives incorrectly

set a review priority: decide when a report should receive attention

link related evidence: connect reports without assuming identical causes

defer with a stated reason: postpone work while preserving the issue and rationale

Debrief findings without inventing coverage

The charter focused on ___ within ___ minutes.

I observed ___ under ___ conditions.

This is a concern pending ___; we did not explore ___.

Exploratory testing combines learning and test design as the session develops. A timebox bounds effort, not coverage. Explain why a clue was followed and distinguish demonstrated failures from concerns whose expected behavior is unsettled.

Word combinations in this lesson

follow an emerging clue: adapt the next check to a relevant observation

debrief a testing session: explain activities, findings, and gaps after the session

distinguish a concern from a defect: separate a question needing a rule from a demonstrated mismatch

bound a finding's scope: state which users, inputs, and conditions were actually examined

Separate evidence from the release decision

Of ___ planned checks, ___ passed, ___ failed, and ___ were blocked.

The agreed criterion remains unmet because ___.

___ owns the decision; this summary establishes ___.

Blocked is not passed or failed behavior: the intended check could not be completed. A pass percentage needs a clear denominator, and outstanding critical evidence matters even when most executed tests pass.

Word combinations in this lesson

report by result category: separate passed, failed, blocked, and unexecuted checks

state the evidence cutoff: identify the latest build and time included in a summary

hand over an unresolved risk: transfer an open concern with its evidence and owner

assess an exit criterion: compare actual evidence with an agreed completion condition

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Agreeing the expected result

A fictional booking feature says cancellations are allowed 'within 24 hours.' One example allows cancellation exactly 24 hours before the event; another rejects it. Time-zone handling is outside this exercise. The requirement owner can clarify the equality case.

The phrase within twenty-four hours leaves the boundary unclear, and the two examples disagree at exactly twenty-four hours before the event. Which outcome is intended at equality? I need an agreed acceptance criterion to judge that case. Until then, I can report the observed result, but I cannot assign a defensible pass or fail against these conflicting examples.

Try it again: Someone says the current implementation should define correctness automatically. Explain why reproducing existing behavior does not settle conflicting requirements.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Making a failure reproducible

A fictional tester sees an export omit the last selected item in build Q12, using a saved selection of three items. A developer's one-item attempt succeeds. The tester reproduced the omission twice in two attempts; no other build or selection size has been checked.

Could you repeat the export on Q12 with the saved three-item selection, rather than a new one-item selection? The last selected item was omitted in both recorded attempts. Those starting conditions differ from your passing attempt. I can provide the saved selection and action order; we have not established behavior for other builds or selection sizes.

Try it again: A screenshot shows missing output but not the starting selection. Explain which reproduction detail still needs to accompany it.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Choosing cases at boundaries and across rules

A fictional form accepts whole-number quantities from 1 through 20 inclusive and rejects values outside that range. A proposed test set contains 5, 10, and 15 only. Decimal handling is unspecified and outside the stated whole-number rule.

Five, ten, and fifteen all sample the accepted interior. They do not check the limits or their neighboring rejected values. For the stated whole-number rule, zero, one, twenty, and twenty-one would examine both boundaries. Decimal handling is a separate unresolved rule; we should not assign its expected result by extending the whole-number requirement.

Try it again: A teammate offers negative one hundred as the only rejected case. Explain why near-boundary rejected values address a different risk.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Explaining coverage and change risk

A fictional account update passes a smoke test covering sign-in and opening the account page. The update changes a formatter used by both account-save and the existing export path; neither path has been tested. One hour is available for further checking; no claim of full coverage is justified.

The smoke test shows that sign-in and page opening work in this build. It does not exercise save or export, both of which use the changed formatter. With one hour, I would prioritize those two paths over repeating page opening. That is a risk-based selection, not a claim that the entire account area has been tested.

Try it again: A stakeholder calls requirement linkage proof of successful execution. Distinguish a mapped test from a test actually run with a result.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Investigating inconsistent automated results

In a fictional automated suite on build T8, a search check fails after a cleanup check but passes when run alone. The cleanup check removes a shared sample record that the search check expects. No code change occurs between these observations.

The search check passes alone but fails after cleanup on the same build. Cleanup removes the sample record that search expects, which supports a test-isolation explanation for these observations. We should preserve the failure and correct the shared starting-state assumption. This finding does not by itself establish that every search behavior in the product is correct.

Try it again: A colleague proposes reporting only the final passing attempt. Explain why the sequence and initial failure belong in the evidence.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | Separating impact from scheduling in triage

A fictional export defect affects one monthly workflow and omits the final row. A visible heading typo affects every account page. Tomorrow's customer demonstration uses that page; no export is planned. The team must discuss impact and timing separately, without assuming either issue is already approved for release.

Let's separate the two decisions. The export defect loses a row in one workflow; the heading typo affects presentation on every account page. Tomorrow's demonstration may influence scheduling, but it does not make the typo's functional impact greater. Could we agree each issue's impact first, then state the reason for its repair priority and any release concern?

Try it again: A teammate wants to close a second report as duplicate because its title matches. Ask for the affected build, steps, and linked evidence first.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Reporting exploratory findings

A fictional twenty-minute exploratory session has the charter 'investigate interrupted profile edits.' The tester finds that navigating away after a saved edit preserves the value; navigating away during an unsaved edit loses it without warning. Whether a warning is required is unspecified. Mobile behavior was not explored.

In the twenty-minute interrupted-edit session, saved values survived navigation. Unsaved values were lost without a warning in the desktop path I explored. The requirement does not yet say whether a warning is expected, so I am reporting that as a usability concern for clarification. Mobile behavior remains outside this session's evidence.

Try it again: A new clue consumes the final five minutes. Explain which original path was left unexamined rather than stretching the timebox into a full-coverage claim.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Giving a release-evidence handover

A fictional candidate Q20 has ten planned checks: seven passed, one failed, and two blocked by unavailable sample data. The agreed exit criterion requires all critical-path checks executed and reviewed; one blocked check is critical. Mara owns the release decision, which has not been made.

For Q20, seven checks passed, one failed, and two were blocked by unavailable sample data. One blocked check is on the critical path, so the stated execution-and-review criterion is not yet met. Mara, please take the failed result and blocked critical check into the release decision. The summary provides evidence; it does not itself approve release.

Try it again: Someone reports seven passes out of eight executed checks and omits the two blocked checks. Explain both the executed denominator and the full planned scope.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

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Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: Software Developers, Quality Assurance Analysts, and Testers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/computer-and-information-technology/software-developers.htm>

International Software Testing Qualifications Board: Certified Tester Foundation Level overview

<https://istqb.org/certifications/certified-tester-foundation-level-ctfl-v4-0/>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Software Quality Assurance and Testing English

Professional audience: Software quality assurance analysts, manual testers, test engineers, automation engineers, and test leads

Scope: All products, builds, test data, results, and incidents are fictional English-language practice, not a testing certification course, security assessment, implementation manual, or release authorization. Quality assurance includes broader quality practices; these lessons focus on testing communication within those roles. Use the actual product contract, tools, evidence, qualified reviewers, and local decision responsibilities in real work. No specific platform behavior or universal defect-rating scheme is implied.

Lesson 01: Agreeing the expected result

Original fictional case: A fictional booking feature says cancellations are allowed 'within 24 hours.' One example allows cancellation exactly 24 hours before the event; another rejects it. Time-zone handling is outside this exercise. The requirement owner can clarify the equality case.

Language workshop: Ask what makes the result correct

Communication goal: Resolve a missing expectation before assigning a test verdict.

Language guidance: A test oracle is the basis for judging the result, not necessarily another program. When wording and examples conflict, state the precise input whose outcome is uncertain and ask the responsible person to settle it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): For input ___, source A expects ___ while source B expects ___. / Which source should govern the equality case? / The observed result is ___; the expected result is still ___.

Vocabulary: test oracle: A source or method used to determine whether an observed software result is acceptable or correct. / acceptance criterion: A specific condition that a feature or change must satisfy to be accepted by the relevant stakeholders. / expected result: The outcome a test is meant to check against

a stated requirement or other justified basis. / ambiguity: Wording or evidence that permits more than one plausible interpretation of intended behavior.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Requirement owner: agree, for this fictional exercise, that cancellation exactly twenty-four hours before the event is allowed; wording beyond that equality case still needs review.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone says the current implementation should define correctness automatically. Explain why reproducing existing behavior does not settle conflicting requirements.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The phrase within twenty-four hours leaves the boundary unclear, and the two examples disagree at exactly twenty-four hours before the event. Which outcome is intended at equality? I need an agreed acceptance criterion to judge that case. Until then, I can report the observed result, but I cannot assign a defensible pass or fail against these conflicting examples.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Retrieve occupational vocabulary

1. Select four terms from the reference. Explain each in plain English, give two natural collocations and quote or create a short workplace example. Label invented examples. Contrast each term with a plausible confusable term; acknowledge regional variation.
2. Present one role-labelled exchange with one missing word or phrase and four choices A-D. Exactly one choice must fit the stated facts and grammar. Stop and wait for my answer before revealing it.
3. Explain all four options, then invite me to read the completed exchange aloud. Offer a sentence frame for optional spoken practice, never an open-ended writing assignment.
4. Repeat for the other three terms, one question at a time. Vary the correct letter and the situation; preserve the reference facts. If a choice is ambiguous, replace the item.
5. Finish with two new four-choice collocation questions for later review, with a clearly separate answer key. Do not claim to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT